

Make the best of your audio reporting

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Identifying a story - the pitch

Focus sentence

“Someone does something because XXXX, but...”

* “Someone” is a character. The main character, usually. Could be a group of people, too.

* “Does something” is action. The central thing they do in the story. Ideally, a character isn’t static.

* “Because” is motivation. Why they do this thing.

* And the “but” is the conflict. The rub. The friction. What the character is working against. Sometimes the “but” is a surprise.

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Identifying a story - the pitch

Driving question

What question are you trying to answer?

If you have multiple questions, you probably have multiple stories. Whenever possible, stick to one and answer it well. Your audience will stay with you.

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Identifying a story - the pitch

Driving question

Zoom in and focus!

Instead of: **“How was Ned Lamont able to win this election by a wider margin than 4 years ago, despite ongoing inflation?”**

More focused: ***“What demographics or communities helped Ned Lamont win the election by a wider margin and why?”***

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Getting ready

Prep your questions

Let your research guide your initial questions.

Think about what your audience wants to learn.

Don't assume because you know something, your listeners will also know.

Also, tap into what your guest is passionate about.

Getting ready

Prep your questions

Tell me about a time when...

How did you go from being x
to being y?

What would the new you say
to the old you?

How did that make you feel?

What was the debate going on
in your head?

What did you make of that?
(If you notice they want to
say more about something)

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The interview

Ask those Qs

- Actively listen
- Follow up
- Push back
- Ask for clarification
- Ask for dejargonization
- Rephrase the question if you think the answer is missing the point



Gathering audio

Looking for active sound
and scene setters

Anticipate the sounds. Talk to your subjects before you go into the field. Ask them when something is happening and go at that time. Ask them what the place sounds like. Ask them if the players can be there when you arrive.

What about the equipment? Will you be far away from the action? Bring a shotgun mic. Will the subject be moving around? Maybe a lavalier mic is needed. If you're outside, remember a dead cat

What would be the perfect tape? Think about what would be really cool in the story and look for it when you are in a scene. Prepare your ear.

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Gathering audio

Looking for active sound
and scene setters

Look for people DOING something and get it on tape.

Pick out the specific sounds - In addition to the sound of traffic, look for the sound of a specific car. Try and isolate individual elements.

Look beyond stereotypical/cliche sounds - The school bell, the traffic roar, the person answering the phone are used a lot. Listen deeper. What sounds are unique to this place, this event, this moment.

If the surroundings are quiet, then look for human moments. Laughter. People telling a story. The sound of someone changing their mind or getting interrupted by someone else. Make your characters describe the scene.

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Gathering audio

Reflect

Take time to log your audio, if you can, as soon as you can, but especially write down your impressions of the interview. Gather details and color to build the scene and to help you introduce a character.

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Gathering audio

Anticipating the sounds
exercise

**What sounds might you
anticipate in these
scenarios?**

A conductor and orchestra
preparing for a performance
of just discovered piece of
music.

A teacher instructing
children on how to dissect a
frog.

— — —

Gathering audio

Listening exercise

Listen to the following stories and take notes about the sounds that you hear (not including music or voices/interviews,) what they evoke and how they help tell the story and set the scene. And can you identify the focus sentence? How does the writing build on the sound?

<https://www.nhpr.org/nh-news/2018-05-16/radio-field-trip-dog-sledding-with-out-snow>

<https://transom.org/2021/in-focus-ways-to-home-in-on-the-core-of-a-story/>

<https://www.npr.org/sections/goatsand soda/2023/10/06/1203891520/drought-climate-change-fog-harvesting>

— — —

Now you write

Bottom Line:
Write the way we talk.

Conversational writing is our goal. The fastest way to get there is to read your copy aloud while writing. Contractions are okay. Fragments, okay!

Write for clarity. Our listener is often doing something else and can't easily rewind.

Keep a specific listener in mind while writing. Tell that person your story: your significant other, your parent, your neighbor

— — —

Now you write

Bottom Line:
Write the way we talk.

If you get stuck while writing, record yourself telling someone your story. Listen for how you prioritize facts and quote from sources. This will help you figure out how to structure your story.

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Give it some structure

**Remember your driving
question?**

Give it some structure

What is my story not about?

Communicate clearly and memorably.

That requires leaving things out.

Will this help answer the question for listeners?

Will it distract, or diffuse, the focus?

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Give it some structure

What will the audience remember when it's over?

Listeners rarely remember entire stories. They'll remember a quote, scenes, characters or ideas.



Give it some structure

Imagine the listener has just finished listening to your story. What are they thinking about? Are they left with a question to ponder? An idea that expands their thinking?

Give it some structure

A few story structures to experiment with.

The basic 3 act structure:

Beginning, middle and end

At a meeting:

- Audio from before the meeting
- audio from the meeting
- audio after the meeting.

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Give it some structure

A few story structures to experiment with.

Beginning, middle and end

At a meeting:

- What do you want the meeting to address? What's at stake?
- The meeting itself
- How do you think the meeting addressed your concerns? Has your opinion changed? What next?

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Give it some structure

The American Life

- This happened, then this happened, then this happened
- REFLECTION OR CONTEXT OR SURPRISE/TWIST
- Then this happened, then this happened
- CLOSING THOUGHTS



Give it some structure

The All Things Considered

- An opening scene where you introduce listeners to a character often in action.
- Context, background – this is the bulk of your reporting/research.
- A return to the original scene. Perhaps time has passed and the character is doing something new. End close to where you started.

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Give it some structure

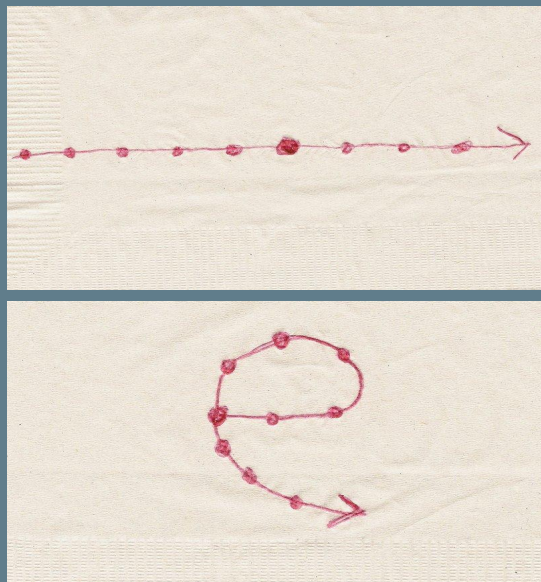
The E

- An opening scene with character/characters in action
- Widen to give context, or go back in time for some history of the action or of the characters or of the conflict. You can switch to a scene that precedes your opening scene.
- Loop back to your opening scene and pick up where you left off, hopefully with a climax and/or resolution.

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Give it some structure

The E



Lay out the chronology/timeline of a story. Chose a compelling point along the timeline. Maybe a point of high tension/conflict. Try it as the beginning of your story. From there, zoom back in time and then rejoin the point where you started. Move the story forward past that point.

Give it some structure

<https://www.npr.org/sections/health-shots/2012/11/27/165282684/to-fight-tick-borne-disease-someone-has-to-catch-ticks>

Questions? Story ideas you'd like to workshop?